



MEDVEDEV LACKED THE ATHLETICISM, VOLLEY, AND STAMINA TO DEFEAT ALCARAZ

down. I think that's the lesson for today."

It may seem harsh to downplay the final as anticlimactic given that Medvedev ranks No. 4 in the world and that he defeated Alcaraz in the US Open semifinals just six months ago. But even on his best surface, hard courts, and in fine form at Indian Wells — beating No. 29 Sebastian Korda, No. 13 Grigor Dimitrov, No. 7 Holger Rune, and No. 17 Tommy Paul — Medvedev lacks the athleticism, volley, and stamina to defeat Alcaraz, Sinner, and Djokovic... if the GOAT regains his form and motivation.

Motivation may be a larger factor than many considered following Djokovic's surprise announcement on March 16 of his withdrawal from the Miami Open on social media, saying he needs to balance his "private and professional schedule."

Former world No. 12 Paolo Bertolucci revealed the cause of Djokovic's malaise. "I spoke with some Serbian colleagues.

Apparently, at the moment, Djokovic's head is not very focused on tennis," Bertolucci told Sky Sports Italia. "He will probably take some days off and then try to reach his best level for the clay season."

Djokovic looked happy and relaxed when he attended the March 16 Warriors-Lakers game in Los Angeles. An NBA fan, especially of fellow Serb superstar Nikola Jokic, Novak swapped a tennis racket for an autographed jersey with Steph Curry.

For the record, Alcaraz outclassed Medvedev 7-6 (5), 6-1 to become only the second man since 1990 to win five Masters 1000 titles before turning 21 — the other being compatriot Rafael Nadal. The triumph was also Alcaraz's fourth in his last five matches against the Russian, without giving up a single set in any of them.

Hitting his forehand harder than ever at 82 mph and returning serve 7-8 feet closer to the baseline than usual, Medvedev surged to a 3-0

Big shoes to fill: Alcaraz outclassed Medvedev to become only the second man since 1990 to win five Masters 1000 titles before turning 21 — the other being Rafael Nadal. GETTYIMAGES

lead. From then on, "The Octopus" couldn't contain the Spaniard's aggression.

"Alcaraz has as much power per pound as anyone in men's tennis," said Courier.

Other than lapses in concentration and shot selection, Alcaraz doesn't have any weaknesses, either.

Some experts might pick out the Alcaraz backhand as a relative weakness compared to his many strengths or the backhands of Djokovic and Sinner. Not Medvedev. When asked about the best shots he's ever faced, the Russian surprisingly included Alcaraz's backhand.

"He's back! Watch out, rest of the tour!" said Paul Annacone, a *Tennis Channel* analyst.